

The Long Way Home

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is brave, loyal, and full of ideas. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

The long quarrel was over at last, and it had ended in the most surprising way of all: not with spears or fire, but with friendship. The great honey-coloured gates of Troy stood open in the morning sun, and the two old camps shared their bread like neighbours. Now only one journey remained, the longest of them all. It was time to sail home across the Wine-Dark Sea, all the way back to the Weaving Hall, where a warm fire, a homecoming feast, and old friends had been waiting through all the long years away.

Odysseus the Bright walked the two of you down to where the ships lay beached on the long sand. "It is a long way home," he said, looking out at the wide and restless water, "and the sea keeps its own counsel. But you are full of ideas, you are brave, and you keep faith with your friends, and that is worth more on a voyage than a hold full of treasure."

Into your hands he pressed three gifts for the road: a great spiral Conch Horn that sounded a warm, calling note across the water; a Basket of Honey and Figs to share with any wary stranger; and a ball of strong weaving thread, Penelope's Thread, which always leads a traveller home. "Remember," he said, "out on the wide sea we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, by keeping faith, and by being full of ideas."



What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry on the voyage: Imagination, Courage, or Loyalty?

Stop 1 The Isle of Winds

You sailed for many days, until one bright morning a strange island rose from the sea ahead, ringed all around with cliffs of shining bronze that floated upon the water as lightly as a cork. This was the Isle of Winds, the home of Aeolus, Keeper of the Winds, who kept every gust and gale of the whole world tied up safely inside a great leather wind-bag.

Aeolus met you with a friendly face, but he was a careful host. He would lend a fair wind, he explained, only to travellers who asked him with a good idea and courteously, and who were not greedy enough to go peeking after more than they needed. "Ask me well," he said, with a twinkle, "and give me your word you will never untie the wind-bag to peep inside it. The wind is a gift, not a treasure to be hoarded."



How will you ask Aeolus for a fair wind? Can you find good, courteous words, and perhaps a promise that you will not peek inside the bag? What is your plan?

When you asked him with a good idea and kindly, and gave your word, Aeolus threw back his head and laughed with delight. He gathered a gentle westerly wind in his hands and tied it softly into your sail. "A fair wind for friends who know how to ask," he said, and the bronze cliffs sank away behind you as your ship leapt forward over the waves.

Stop 2 The Singing Sirens

For many quiet days you sailed on, with Aeolus's wind steady at your back. Then, one still afternoon, you heard it drift across the water: a song. It was the most beautiful thing you had ever heard, and also the saddest, a melody so full of longing that it seemed to tug at the very rudder of your ship. It came from the Singing Sirens, the sea-singers who sat upon a circle of lonely rocks, and ship after ship had drifted off course down the years just to follow that aching tune.

But this was no danger to flee from, though your heart might race to hear it. Listen closely. There was no wickedness in that song at all. The Sirens were only lonely, terribly lonely, for in all their long years not one single sailor had ever stopped to be their friend.

★ *This was never a fight, and it was never a race to slip away unseen. What kindness could you offer the Sirens instead? You might sing a warm song back to them across the water. You might sound the Conch Horn so its kindly note reached their rocks. You might share your Basket of Honey and Figs. What do you try?*

When you answered their loneliness with kindness, the saddest song in all the sea faltered and changed. The Sirens lifted their heads in wonder, and then they laughed, a sound that had not been heard on those rocks for a hundred years. They sang again, but now their song was bright and glad, and it wound around your ship like a friendly hand and guided you safely through the rocks. "Come back and visit us one day!" they called after you, waving until the rocks were small behind you.

Stop 3 Home at Last

At last, far across the bright water, a low green shore came into view, and something in you went very still and very sure. Was this truly home, after all this time? You leaned over the rail and looked, and looked again, for you had to be certain.

The ship slid up onto a sand you half remembered, and you followed a winding path up from the shore until the Weaving Hall stood before you, just as it always had. Through the open door you could see the great loom standing in the firelight, with a half-finished weaving on it, as though someone had been working there patiently all the while you were gone. An old friend glanced up from beside the loom. And there, curled by the hearth, a grey old dog raised his head and tested the air with his nose.

★ *How will you know, truly know, that you are home? What do you remember of this place? Look for the great loom, for the face of an old friend, for the faithful hound by the fire. Who is it that waits there?*

It was Argos the Faithful Hound, who never in all his long life had forgotten a friend or a scent. For a moment he simply stared. Then he scrambled up on his stiff old legs and trotted to you, his tail wagging so hard that the whole of him wagged with it, and you knew, past all doubt, that you were home at last.

Home at Last

The Weaving Hall filled with warmth and golden light. The homecoming feast was laid along the long table: fresh bread still warm from the oven, ripe figs, and clear honey. Old friends threw their arms around you and called you by your hero name, hardly able to believe that the long way home was done. And Argos the Faithful Hound would not be parted from your side, not for one single moment.

Far out over the calm and shining sea, Thetis the Sea-Mother looked up from the gentle waves and smiled. You had crossed the whole wide Wine-Dark Sea, from the windswept shores of Troy to your own warm door, and you had done it together: with your courage, with your imagination, and above all by keeping faith with one another. Well done, heroes of the windswept shores. Welcome home.

The Long Way Home: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, with a wide sea and a long voyage and the pull of a lonely song, but good ideas and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp on the shores of Troy.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart on a wide sea), or **Loyalty** (keeping faith with a friend). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: any spiral shell or cup for the Conch Horn, a small basket or token for the Basket of Honey and Figs, and a ball of string for Penelope's Thread. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Loyalty together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On this long voyage, no hero sails alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Odysseus the Bright gives you one free hint.
2	You find your sea-legs again, and take back one energy star.
3	A fair wind fills the sail, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well.
5	A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The Singing Sirens by the rocks are the "obstacle" of the voyage, but they are no villains. They are sea-singers who have been lonely too long, and their sad song pulls ships off course only because no one has ever stopped to befriend them. The tale is won not by fleeing them and not by any kind of force, but by answering their loneliness with kindness: a song sung back, the Conch Horn sounded, the Basket of Honey and Figs shared. Once the Sirens are cheered and befriended, they sing the heroes safely on their way. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. The last stop is the gentle joy of coming home to the Weaving Hall. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Long Way Home: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Isle of Winds (Normal)

The challenge. Aeolus, Keeper of the Winds, will lend a fair wind only to travellers who ask him with a good idea and courteously, and who are not greedy enough to peek inside his wind-bag. The players must win his help with good manners and a good, honest request.

The riddle. If your heroes enjoy a puzzle, let Aeolus set one before he agrees: "*I have no hands, yet I fill a sail. I have no voice, yet I make the whole sea wail. You cannot see me, catch me, or keep me in a sack for long. What am I?*" The answer is **the wind** itself.

Intended solution. This is a challenge of Imagination and Courage. The bright, courteous move is to ask Aeolus plainly and politely for just a fair wind home, to thank him, and to promise faithfully not to untie the wind-bag to peek inside. Solving his little wind riddle works just as well. Reward good manners, an honest request, and any promise not to be greedy.

Fallback. If the children are stuck, have Aeolus give them a warm hint ("A kind word and a promise are all I ask, young sailors") or let them spend an energy star to find the right words together. A request made bravely and politely always earns the fair wind.

Stop 2: The Singing Sirens (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. The Singing Sirens sit on the lonely rocks, and their song is so sad and so lovely that it pulls ships off course. The players may feel this is a danger to flee, or even to fight. It is neither.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Loyalty (kindness) and Courage. The Sirens are not wicked, only lonely; no one has ever stayed to be their friend. Any genuine kindness works: singing a warm song back to them, sounding the **Conch Horn** so its friendly note reaches the rocks, sharing the **Basket of Honey and Figs**, or simply calling out a kind hello. When the children answer the loneliness with kindness, the Sirens cheer up, and their bright new song guides the ship safely past the rocks. There is no roll to escape; the kindness is the answer.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by rowing away as fast as they can, have one Siren call across the water, very softly, "Will nobody ever stop and sing with us?" A single kind word or note from the Conch Horn turns the sad song glad and the Sirens become friends at once.

Stop 3: Home at Last (Normal)

The challenge. The heroes reach a green shore that may be home. They must cross the last stretch and be sure, then recognise the Weaving Hall and the friends waiting inside.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Loyalty and Observation. The bright and loyal move is to remember the marks of home: the great loom standing in the firelight, the face of an old friend, and above all **Argos the Faithful Hound** by the hearth, who knows them at once. Naming what they remember, or calling the old dog's name, settles it beyond doubt and the homecoming begins.

Fallback. If the children are unsure whether this is truly home, let Argos settle it: the old hound lifts his grey head, catches their scent, and trots straight to them with his tail wagging, because he has never once forgotten a friend. Recognising home with the dog's help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the heroes step into the Weaving Hall, the homecoming feast is laid, old friends call them by their hero names, Argos the Faithful Hound will not leave their side, and far out on the calm sea **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles up at them. The whole Wine-Dark Sea is crossed and the long way home is done. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, loyal, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.